

have set aside funds for family emergencies before you invest,” and “Deal with the facts, not tips or rumors.”

In recounting the history of the stock market, the New York Stock Exchange was quite frank in describing the treacherous past, when rumor mongers, shills, and connivers victimized the average investor and took most of his money. About recent times the exchange was not so pessimistic. It told of the remarkable reforms that have been effected, and of the great improvement in the shareholders' chances. “Investment objectives,” a recording concluded, “have changed from quick-dollar schemes to savings-oriented vehicles concerned with long-term security.”

Beyond the education gallery there's a large overhead ticker tape, similar to the ones I'd seen in the local broker's offices. A crowd of visitors stood at attention, gazing respectfully skyward, and I was happy to join them. How exhilarating it was to watch the march of stock quotes across the ceiling, in the very building these quotes are produced. I was told that every trade of 100 shares or more from every investor in the world, no matter how piddling, gets its blip of fame, flashed here and on thousands of other screens around the globe. For those few seconds after every deal is made, the resulting IBM 133 $\frac{1}{2}$ or SLB 40 $\frac{3}{4}$ inspires millions of viewers to groan, cheer, and perhaps to take action. If only you could tell which IBM 133 $\frac{1}{2}$ might actually be yours!

The tour guide stood on a semicircular platform below the overhead tape and entertained us with interesting facts. She said the New York Stock Exchange had 11 major computer systems that could handle 415 million shares a day, soon to be expanded to 500 million. A 500-million-share day hadn't happened yet but they were preparing for it, just as a 150-million-share day, inconceivable in the 1960s, was the current norm. In the early 1920s they were lucky to have a 150-million-share year. Back then, it took a year to trade as many shares as now changed hands in a week of active sessions.

As to what accounted for this phenomenal increase in buying and selling, I got two explanations. First, there were more shares than there used to be. On the New York Stock Exchange alone there were 51 billion shares in 1,500 companies whose stocks trade here. On the nearby American Stock Exchange there were seven